

A 4
B₁ 4
B₂ 4
C 4
D 4

May 2023 Paper 2: Sample Response 5

Question 1: Referring to two works you have studied, discuss how the writers portray the significance of a journey.

The significance of a journey varies for individuals. It can range from a physical displacement to a mental or personal journey in overcoming a challenge. The play Death and the Maiden by Ariel Dorfman explores the journey that the three main characters take in overcoming their unnamed country's shift from a dictatorship to a democracy. Human Acts by Han Kang explores the manner in which Korean society dealt with the decade long aftermath of the 1980 Gwangju student uprising. Both writers tackle the significance of a journey through their characters experiences and character development, which is highlighted in the structure and form of the literary works. They also use symbolism, narrative structure, and motifs to portray these varied journeys for their characters.

Firstly, in Death and the Maiden, Dorfman makes use of a chronological sequence over a period of 24 hours in a single setting, following a classical Greek structure of a play. One of the central themes explores Paulina's journey in overcoming her traumatic experience of being tortured while another key theme depicts the journey of a country as they transition from being under a dictatorship to becoming a democratic nation. Dorfman depicts Paulina's journey by having her explore her transition from being a fragile victim to a powerful woman capable of regaining justice. Her particular journey is explored through the use of motifs. The gun, being a central motif in the play, symbolizes Paulina's rise in power against her perpetrator and torturer, Roberto. Dorfman portrays the significance of her journey through depicting a woman having power over men by simply holding a gun. It is important to note that the only time Paulina is in the position of power and not being

undermined is when she is in physical possession of the gun. The character is often not taken seriously by Roberto nor is she truly respected by her husband Gerardo. The gun allows her to take that step, that journey from being ignored to being listened to and respected, even it is only because she is holding a powerful weapon. This **motif**, this gun, reminds the audience of Paulina's vulnerability, placing them in her shoes, and thus living her complex journey in a search for justice as they watch the play unfold.

In contrast to all the action occurring in a 24 hour period, in one setting, Han Kang utilises **a non-linear sequence of storytelling over a 30 year period**, to signify and remind the reader that journey's might not always be linear; rather, some journeys span across decades and may even be potentially endless. Similar to Dorfman however, a central theme explored in this novel is the search for justice for young Dong-Ho, who loses his life during the student uprising. His emotionally distraught mother's purpose and journey becomes the search for the justice her son deserves. Like Dorfman, Kang also uses a **motif** to show the journey of the character. The **motif of nature and trees** in the novel **symbolise** an escape from the challenges endured. The trees relate to Dong-Ho's mother's journey in overcoming grief as they are her escape and support system through the loss. This **motif** allows Kang to provide the reader with a nuanced significance of the mother's journey, and the complex emotions she experiences because of her young son's death.

In addition to the use of motifs, Ariel Dorfman portrays the significance of a journey through **the lens of three main characters**, each having a personal journey to overcome. Paulina's journey includes the search for revenge; Roberto's journey is the search for freedom; and Gerardo's journey, Paulina's husband, is figuring out how to uphold his loyalty to the government and morals while also respecting his wife's needs at the same time.

Dorfman makes use of the sea, surrounding Paulina and Gerardo's secluded beach house, to symbolise and bring forth Paulina's changing attitudes. At first, the playwright ensures that the ocean is a symbol for peace and tranquillity, being a support system for Paulina's journey in overcoming trauma. However, this quickly shifts when Paulina holds her torturer captive. The ocean suddenly becomes a symbol for rebirth and chance at a new life as Paulina plots to murder Roberto. The sea becomes a symbol for a journey signifying the chance to begin and start a new life for Paulina. The symbol provides the audience with detailed understanding of the complexities in Paulina's journey in search for revenge.

Han Kang approaches this in a slightly different manner. She explores the significance of a journey through six main narrative perspectives that shift throughout her novel. Additionally, first person as well as second person narrative are used interchangeably to enforce the concept that a journey can have various perspectives and approaches. The second person narrative (point of view) in particular is successful in placing the reader in the shoes of the character. In Chapter 5, the author places the reader in the shoes of the factory girl to successfully bring across and mirror her journey in a hunt for freedom and human rights during the Gwangju uprising. Similar to Dorfman, Kang also makes use of symbols to signify and reflect the journey of individual characters. Han Kang uses the coffin and the dead body as symbols paired with descriptive language of the violent journey protesters and activists put themselves through to protect and stand up for their community against the military. To reinforce the concept of a journey, these symbols make multiple appearances throughout the chapters. Through the presentation of journeys using a series of characters and perspectives, Kang portrays the significance of journey to be almost endless while also very different for all involved.

Finally, Ariel Dorfman makes use of an unusual ending to his play as he intends to not only take his characters on a journey, but his audience as well. At the end of the play Dorfman decides to lower a larger mirror over the stage so that the audience can now see themselves. This forces the audience to reflect on and understand the journey they have been taken on throughout the play. Signifying that the concept of a journey in a play has the power to break the fourth wall for the audience, stating that a journey has no barriers. The mirror takes the audience on a journey by making them place themselves in the shoes of the characters on stage. This further insinuates the complexities of a journey. In addition, it also signifies the individuality of a journey as each audience member presumably and each character has been taken on their own personal journey. On the other hand, instead of a striking ending, Han Kang makes use of a crucial motif towards the end of the novel, which is described to be the destiny of the soul. It is an exploration and a portrayal of the journey the human soul takes after death. Through the first-person narrative perspective, told through the deceased body of Dong-Ho, readers are guided through the spiritual, unfamiliar journey of the afterlife. By doing this, Kang signifies that journeys can go far beyond what is familiar to us readers and can even expand into our souls after passing. The use of the motif, although relevant in the entirety of the novel, primarily becomes striking towards the end of the novel due to its complexity and unfamiliarity. Kang builds a strong connection with the reader through the visceral descriptions of Dong-Ho's deceased body paired with the awareness of his soul.

In conclusion, both playwright Ariel Dorfman and novelist Han Kang are able to portray the rather complex significance of a journey. They manage to illustrate this through the use of various devices such as symbols, motifs and narrative perspectives paired with

more abstract concepts, such as breaking the norms of a play or the inclusion of a spiritual approach in relation to the journey. Ultimately, the authors demonstrate – through their characters – that journeys are different for every individual, even if they may have a wider, universal meaning attached to them.

Word count: 1334